STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



AI

AI IN THE MANAGER'S WORK, WITHOUT ILLUSIONS

What the experiments measure when people work with AI, where it helps and where it misleads, and what the manager has to set before the team relies on it.

19% more time was needed by experienced developers for tasks on which they could use AI. They believed AI had made them 20% faster.

METR, 2025

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In this issue

Half of US employees now use AI in their work at least now and then. Between what AI seems to do and what can be measured lies a gap, and it is the manager who has to decide inside it.

In 2025 experienced developers believed AI had made them faster, while the clock said slower. Other experiments found large gains, mostly for newer people and for tasks inside what researchers call the jagged frontier. Gallup finds that use grows faster than plans, and that the manager's support goes together with whether it helps.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Felt faster, measured slower

In early 2025 the research group METR ran a randomised experiment: 16 experienced developers, 246 real tasks in projects they knew well. Each task was randomly assigned to be done with AI tools or without them.

24%
faster: what the developers expected before

20%
faster: what they believed afterwards

19%
slower: what was measured

Experts in economics and machine learning had forecast tasks almost 40% shorter. METR calls the result a snapshot of early-2025 tools in one setting. In 2026 it said developers are likely faster now and began changing its study design, while still calling self-reported speed-ups unreliable.

2023
Customer support: 14% more cases solved per hour with AI.

2023
Consultants: big gains inside the frontier, worse results outside it.

2025
Developers: 19% slower, with the feeling of being faster.

2026
Gallup: half of US employees use AI at work.

OUR READING

A feeling of speed measures nothing. Before a team changes how it works, someone has to time the work itself, rather than ask how it felt.

Sources: METR, 2025; METR, 2026; Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li & Lindsey Raymond, NBER, 2023; Fabrizio Dell'Acqua, Edward McFowland III, Ethan Mollick et al., Harvard Business School, 2023 (via Abstracts: working paper, 2023; Organization Science, 2026); Gallup, 2026

THE NUMBERS

Half use it, few have a plan

Since 2023 Gallup has asked US employees how often they use AI in their role. Use has more than doubled; the plans have not kept up.

USE AI AT WORK A FEW TIMES A YEAR OR MORE, US, SECOND QUARTER



44%
say their organisation has begun to integrate AI (2025)

22%
say a clear plan was communicated to them (2025)

Frequent use, a few times a week or more, rose from 11% in 2023 to 30% in May 2026; 15% now use AI every day.

OUR READING

Use grows from the bottom, while the plan has to come from the top. The manager stands in between and sees both.

Sources: Gallup, 2025; Gallup, 2026

THE MODEL

The jagged frontier

In 2023 Harvard Business School and BCG gave 758 consultants GPT-4 for realistic tasks. The researchers call the line between what AI does well and badly a jagged frontier: tasks that look equally hard can fall on either side of it.

Inside the frontier

- 12.2% more tasks completed
- 25.1% faster
- Over 40% higher quality

Outside the frontier

- 19 percentage points less likely to be correct
- The help of AI made the result worse
- How hard the task looked did not tell the side

In data on 5,179 support agents, the AI assistant raised cases solved per hour by 14% on average. The newest and least skilled gained 34%; the most experienced, almost nothing.

OUR READING

AI helps most where the task is known and the result can be checked. Outside the frontier it needs someone who knows the work well enough to see the mistake.

Sources: Fabrizio Dell'Acqua, Edward McFowland III, Ethan Mollick et al., Harvard Business School, 2023 (via Abstracts: working paper, 2023; Organization Science, 2026); Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li & Lindsey Raymond, NBER, 2023

The frontier is the researchers' term; applying it to a manager's tasks is our reading.

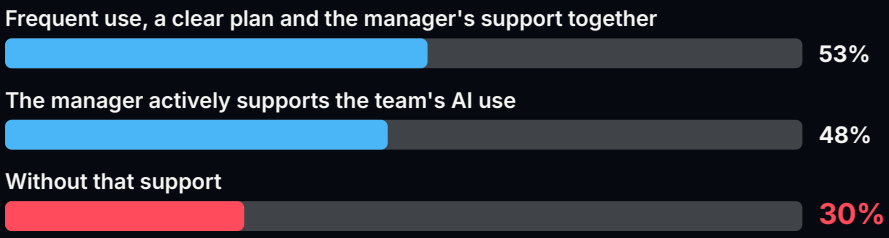
More in the essay — From retail to logistics and hospitality: the industry changes, the management problems do not

THE MANAGER'S PART

Where the manager comes in

In Gallup's 2026 data, the manager's support goes together with whether AI use helps the team or stays a private habit.

ENGAGED EMPLOYEES, US, 2026



36%
strongly agree that their manager supports the team's AI use (organisations integrating AI, May 2026)

40%
received “workslop” in the past month (1,150 US employees, 2025)

Workslop is work made with AI that looks useful but lacks substance. The person who sent it saves time; the person who receives it has to interpret, correct or redo it.

OUR READING

The manager sets the standard: what AI may do, who checks it and what counts as finished. Without a standard, one person's speed becomes the next person's rework.

Sources: Gallup, Employee Engagement Remains Flat as AI Adoption Accelerates, 2026; Gallup, Indicator: Artificial Intelligence, 2026; Kate Niederhoffer et al., Harvard Business Review, 2025

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Measure before you believe

In 2025 a preliminary MIT NANDA report said 95% of organisations saw no measurable return from generative AI and spoke of a “95% failure rate”. It rested on interviews in 52 organisations, 153 leaders surveyed at four conferences and over 300 public projects. Neither a headline nor a feeling replaces measuring your own work.

1. **Choose one task**
   Repeated, known, and with a result you can check.
2. **Measure it without AI**
   Two weeks: time per task and the corrections it needs.
3. **Measure it with AI**
   The same task and the same check, including the time spent checking.
4. **Decide with the numbers**
   Keep, change or stop, and write down who checks.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, THE WEEKLY SHIFT REPORT

Without AI	3 h, 4 corrections
With AI	1 h 10 min + 30 min checking, 1 correction

The saving is real but smaller than it feels: 1 h 20 min a week. (Invented figures.)

Source: Aditya Challapally et al., MIT NANDA, 2025

The steps and the example are the editors'.

More in the essay KPIs do not improve in Excel

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The AI task card

One card for every task you hand to AI. Fill it in with the person who does the task, and look at it again after a month.

01 The task what, how often, for whom

02 Inside or outside the frontier? can a mistake be seen quickly?

03 What AI does, what the person does

04 Who checks, and how before it leaves the team

05 Measured before and after time and corrections

06 Decision and review date keep, change, stop

Suggested by the editors as a practice. Personal or confidential data belong neither in public AI tools nor on the card.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Measuring the Impact of Early-2025 AI on Experienced Open-Source Developer Productivity
METR, 2025
https://metr.org/blog/2025-07-10-early-2025-ai-experienced-os-dev-study/

We are Changing our Developer Productivity Experiment Design
METR, 2026
https://metr.org/blog/2026-02-24-uplift-update/

AI Use at Work Has Nearly Doubled in Two Years
Gallup, 2025
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/691643/work-nearly-doubled-two-years.aspx

Indicator: Artificial Intelligence
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/699797/indicator-artificial-intelligence.aspx

Navigating the Jagged Technological Frontier
Fabrizio Dell'Acqua, Edward McFowland III, Ethan Mollick et al., Harvard Business School, 2023 · via Abstracts: working paper, 2023; Organization Science, 2026
https://papers.ssrn.com/abstract=4573321

Generative AI at Work
Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li & Lindsey Raymond, NBER, 2023
https://www.nber.org/papers/w31161

Employee Engagement Remains Flat as AI Adoption Accelerates
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/712433/employee-engagement-remains-flat-adoption-accelerates.aspx

AI-Generated "Workslop" Is Destroying Productivity
Kate Niederhoffer et al., Harvard Business Review, 2025
https://hbr.org/2025/09/ai-generated-workslop-is-destroying-productivity

The GenAI Divide: State of AI in Business 2025
Aditya Challapally et al., MIT NANDA, 2025

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked "via". The editors' interpretation is marked "Our reading". Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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